

Ecological Commons — Reference Document

For Jonathan Parker, April 22, 2026

1. Current connections and assets

Institutional / fiscal

- **Stewardship Network** — Fiscal sponsor. Lisa Brush, Executive Director. Already holds Seeds to Community. Willing (strongly expected) to extend umbrella to ecological commons. Provides 501(c)(3) status, can receive grants and donations, provides governance/financial/insurance infrastructure.

Built, operational

- **ecologicalcommons.org** — Concept site, public-facing.
- **data.ecologicalcommons.org** — Live data layer (FERNS — Federated Ecological Resource Network System).
- **22 integrated sources** with provenance, permissions tracking, source-relationship graph, known limitations.
- **OpenAPI 3.1 specification** — developer-ready.
- **MCP endpoint** — stood up, for AI agent integration.
- **Proof-of-concept species application** (s2c-species.replit.app).
- **Investigation presentation** — delivered at Stewardship Network conference.

Regional / community

- **Seeds to Community Washtenaw** — Jonathan's program. Existing partnerships with Washtenaw County Parks & Recreation, U-M Seed Library, MBGNA Campus Farm (2026 season partnership).
- **Washtenaw County Parks & Recreation** — Jonathan leads most volunteer invasive species removal events.
- **Ecological burns practitioner** — Jonathan, regional.

Upcoming or offered

- **Douglas Tallamy** — Has offered to connect Jonathan to his NSF data contacts.
- **National Wild Ones President** — Meeting scheduled next month. Wild Ones mission aligned (native plants, Homegrown National Park partnership with Tallamy).
- **Sheila Schuller (SEAS)** — Meeting this week. Past programming overlap with Jonathan's work.
- **Mike Shriberg (SEAS)** — Meeting this week. Personal friend, knows Jonathan's work, kids played together, has attended Seeds to Community workshops.

U-M adjacency (not yet engaged but relevant)

- **Tony Kolenic** — Director, Matthaei Botanical Gardens and Nichols Arboretum. Strategic plan explicitly names biocultural diversity, polycentrism, data infrastructure needs. Existing MBGNA/Campus Farm connection via Seeds to Community.
 - **UMSI (School of Information)** — Home of the Edwards/Borgman/Bowker knowledge-infrastructures lineage that ecological commons is intellectually grounded in. Highest-leverage first introduction.
 - **Carolyn Kuranz (spouse)** — Full Professor of Nuclear Engineering, APS Fellow, 2023 Rackham Faculty Achievement Award, 2026 U-M President's Award for National and State Leadership. Not to be used as referrer. Valuable as informed insider — ground-truth on SEAS/UMSI politics, Rackham flexibility, current funding climate.
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2. Structural options for U-M relationship

Ranked by fit to GBIF-scale ambition.

Option A — Stewardship Network ↔ U-M partnership (MOU)

Shape: Ecological commons stays independent, housed at Stewardship Network. Formal partnership agreement between Stewardship Network and a U-M unit (SEAS, UMSI, or joint). U-M acts as research collaborator, not host.

Pros: Matches how GBIF-scale federated infrastructures actually run. Protects the commons from capture by any single institution. Positions U-M as peer, not parent. Jonathan stays in control of direction.

Cons: Requires a U-M unit willing to sign an MOU. Slower to set up than individual affiliation. Requires more negotiation up front.

Priority: Highest if GBIF-scale ambition is real. This is the structure that scales.

Option B — Research affiliate / visiting scholar appointment + Option A eventually

Shape: Jonathan gets individual U-M affiliation (visiting scholar, research affiliate, or research fellow) hosted by a faculty member at SEAS or UMSI. Provides UM email, library access, building access, class access, formal affiliation for outreach. MOU-style partnership develops later as the relationship matures.

Pros: Faster to set up. Lower commitment on U-M side. Gets Jonathan inside the building. Natural bridge to Option A.

Cons: Individual appointment, not institutional partnership. Doesn't scale on its own.

Priority: High as immediate first step. Likely what Schuller and Shriberg can actually offer this week.

Option C — Co-PI on a planning grant

Shape: A U-M faculty member serves as PI on a planning grant (NSF CSSI, NSF HDR, Moore Foundation, Sloan, Mellon) with Jonathan / Stewardship Network as co-PI or subaward. Planning grant scopes the actual long-term institutional home.

Pros: Brings real money. Creates formal working relationship. NSF program officers often prefer this shape for infrastructure projects. Tallamy's NSF connection is directly useful here.

Cons: Requires identifying the right faculty co-PI first. Requires grant writing. 6–12 months before funded.

Priority: High parallel track. Start conversations this week, develop over the coming months.

Option D — U-M center or initiative designation

Shape: A multi-year process to formally designate an ecological-commons-adjacent research center or initiative at U-M, typically joint across schools (SEAS + UMSI + LSA).

Pros: The "big" institutional home if the project grows that way.

Cons: Years-long process. Requires significant faculty leadership, provost-level support, substantial outside funding already committed. Too early.

Priority: Aspirational. Do not pursue now. May emerge organically from Options A and C.

Option E — Enrolled degree program (PhD, master's, non-traditional)

Shape: Jonathan enrolls as a student in some U-M program, with ecological commons as his research contribution.

Pros: Well-understood mechanism. Guaranteed multi-year affiliation. Potential stipend.

Cons: Wrong shape for the ambition. Programs are structured to produce researchers, not institutions. Coursework requirements will slow the work. Jonathan doesn't need the credential. Five to seven years of constraint.

Priority: Low. Only if no other option is available, and only if a specific program is willing to be bent entirely around the project (rare).

3. Meeting guidance

Default posture for all three U-M meetings this week

- Lead with what is built, not with what you need. Show the system. Let them see it's real.
- Name Stewardship Network as fiscal home. You are not asking U-M to become the fiscal home.
- Frame U-M's potential role as research collaborator and partner, not host.
- Ambition: do not open with "GBIF-scale." Let them arrive at the scale themselves after understanding the architecture.
- Upcoming connections to mention, without making them the center: Tallamy / NSF, National Wild Ones, existing Stewardship Network commitment.
- Ask for one specific next introduction from each meeting.

Schuller (SEAS) — this week

Relationship: Past programming overlap; she knows your work contextually. **Framing:** Practitioner who has built infrastructure relevant to SEAS's applied ecological mission; seeking research partnership. **Lead with:** What's built, how it connects to SEAS-adjacent practitioner work, the Stewardship Network fiscal home. **Ask for:**

- Her read on what SEAS programs or faculty would be appropriate collaborators.
- Whether a SEAS–Stewardship Network partnership structure is feasible.
- Individual affiliate appointment as immediate first step (Option B).

- One introduction, ideally to someone at UMSI or to a SEAS faculty working on ecological informatics. **Do not:** Ask her to fit you into an existing program on her terms. Do not frame as asking for a favor.

Shriberg (SEAS) — this week

Relationship: Personal friend. Has been to your Seeds to Community workshops. Knows your work is real and substantial. **Framing:** Direct. Warm. You're telling a friend what you've built and asking him to help you figure out the right shape. **Lead with:** "Here's what I built. Here's what I need. What do you think, and who else should I be talking to?" **Ask for:**

- His honest assessment of Options A, B, and C — which one SEAS could actually make happen.
- A UMSI introduction. This is the highest-leverage ask. Specifically name UMSI and the knowledge-infrastructures research area.
- Names of SEAS faculty who should be in the conversation.
- His willingness to be an internal advocate or co-conspirator, not just a sponsor. **Do not:** Be more formal than the relationship warrants. He's a friend. Use that.

Tony Kolenic (MBGNA) — not yet scheduled, should happen

Relationship: Not yet engaged, but high structural alignment. His 2023–2027 strategic plan explicitly names biocultural diversity, polycentrism, data infrastructure needs, and the user-first framing ecological commons is built around. Existing Campus Farm / Seeds to Community connection provides natural bridge. **Framing:** Not asking for partnership or resources. Twenty-minute conversation to share what you're building because it intersects Pillar IV of his strategic plan and the existing Seeds to Community relationship. **Lead with:** The overlap — your Seeds to Community work, the Campus Farm adjacency, what ecological commons is and why it fits the plan's language of biocultural diversity and user-centered experience. **Ask for:** Nothing concrete on the first meeting. The relationship is the ask. He is likely receptive based on his public writing and the plan. A second conversation down the road may produce MBGNA as a pilot site for tools built on the commons. **Do not:** Ask MBGNA to govern, fund, or host the commons. The right relationship is lighter-touch than that.

National Wild Ones President — next month

Relationship: Mission-aligned national organization. Already-planned meeting. **Framing:** Ecological commons aligns directly with Wild Ones' mission and the Homegrown National Park partnership with Tallamy. You are offering Wild Ones an opportunity to be an early partner in infrastructure that serves their members nationally. **Ask for:**

- Data partnership: any datasets Wild Ones holds that could be integrated.
- Programmatic partnership: bootcamps or tools for chapter leaders built on the commons.
- Potentially a seat at the table as the commons scales (advisory role, not governance yet). **Do not:** Agree to co-sponsor or co-convene structure at this meeting. Stewardship Network is the fiscal home. Wild Ones is programmatic partner initially. Structural evolution comes later if the relationship matures.

Douglas Tallamy / NSF connection — timing flexible

Relationship: Tallamy has offered the connection. You have not used it yet. **Framing:** Request a thirty-minute informal call with the NSF program officer(s) most relevant to cyberinfrastructure for ecological data (likely CSSI or HDR program areas). **Ask for:**

- Which NSF program is the best fit for ecological commons.
- Whether an informal pre-submission conversation is appropriate.
- What a planning grant (Option C) would need to look like to be competitive. **When to activate:** After this week's SEAS meetings, so you have U-M affiliation forming as context for the NSF conversation. Ideally before or right after the Wild Ones meeting.

Carolyn — ongoing

Relationship: Spouse, full professor, Rackham-award-winning U-M insider. **Framing:** Informed insider who can ground-truth what Schuller and Shriberg tell you. **Ask for:**

- Her read on current SEAS and UMSI politics and funding climate.
- Rackham's flexibility for non-traditional appointments.
- Anyone she knows at UMSI specifically in knowledge-infrastructure or data-curation work. **Do not:** Ask her to intervene or refer. Use her as informant, not as advocate.

4. Priority order for the next 30 days

1. **Schuller and Shriberg meetings this week.** Goal: at least one concrete next step (affiliate appointment discussion, UMSI introduction, or faculty contact).
2. **Confirm Stewardship Network fiscal sponsorship of ecological commons formally with Lisa Brush.** Currently informal/implicit. Get it explicit in writing.
3. **Request UMSI introduction from whichever SEAS contact is willing to make it.** This

is the single highest-leverage door.

4. **Reach out to Tony Kolenic** for a twenty-minute conversation. Low stakes, high alignment.
 5. **Activate Tallamy's NSF offer** after the SEAS meetings have produced some initial U-M context.
 6. **Prepare for Wild Ones meeting next month** with a clear picture of what you want from that relationship (programmatic partnership, not structural co-sponsor).
 7. **Hold off on data-hosting permission letters to national organizations** until U-M affiliation is in place. Regional and relationship-based asks can proceed now.
 8. **Write the one-page project summary** tuned for academic readers. Use for all U-M and NSF outreach. (Claude can draft this in next conversation.)
 9. **Write the one-page lightweight governance statement.** Before it's needed. (Claude can draft this in next conversation.)
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5. What not to do

- Do not enroll in a degree program this cycle. Let mechanism emerge from conversations.
 - Do not let Wild Ones or any other single organization become structural co-convener before the relationships have matured.
 - Do not ask Carolyn to refer or intervene. Use her as informant only.
 - Do not let U-M capture or rebrand the commons. Partnership, not hosting.
 - Do not pursue national data-hosting permissions before U-M affiliation is in place.
 - Do not rush. You said you will do this for the rest of your life. Governance before scale. The right second person before the wrong grant. The right faculty sponsor before the flashy meeting.
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6. What Claude can help you build next

Drafts, in priority order, for the next conversation (non-incognito so it persists):

1. One-page project summary for academic / funder outreach.

2. Email to whoever at UMSI gets named as the right contact.
 3. Email to Tony Kolenic.
 4. Talking points for the Wild Ones meeting.
 5. One-page lightweight governance statement.
 6. Draft of what a Stewardship Network ↔ U-M MOU could cover.
 7. Decision framework for yes/no at scale.
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End of document.